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Shashwat Dhar

Appointments

Swarthmore College — Swarthmore, USA
Visiting Assistant Professor of Global Studies — Fall 2025-Present

Education

Vanderbilt University — Nashville, USA
Ph.D., Political Science — 2025
- Dissertation: *Exit as 'Disengagement': The Political Implications of Economic Migration in Rural India*
- Committee: Jonathan Hiskey (Chair), Nina McMurry, Noam Lupu, Tariq Thachil, Guillermo Toral
- Primary subfield: Comparative Politics

Tata Institute of Social Sciences — Mumbai, India
M.A., Development Studies — 2015
- Thesis: *Exploring the Rise of Citizen Politics in Contemporary India*

University of Delhi — Delhi, India
B.A. (Hons.), Political Science — 2013

Research interests

Comparative Political Behavior. Political Economy of Development. Politics of Migration and Environmental Change. Ethnic and Identity Politics. Mixed-Methods and Field Research. Politics of South Asia.

Publications

Peer-Reviewed Articles

- Kumar, Ashwani, Souradeep Banerjee, and **Shashwat Dhar**. 2021. "Pathways of Money: Insights from the 2017 Gujarat Assembly Election." *India Review* 19(5): 448–470.

Book Chapters

- Kumar, Ashwani, and **Shashwat Dhar**. 2024. "The Politics of Interstate Migration in India." In *The Oxford Handbook of Indian Politics*, eds. Sumit Ganguly and Eswaran Sridharan. Oxford: Oxford University Press: 327–346.
- Kumar, Ashwani, and **Shashwat Dhar**. 2021. "Migration and Inclusive Elections." In *Migrants, Mobility and Citizenship in India*, eds. Ashwani Kumar and R.B. Bhagat. New York: Routledge: 51–64.
- Dhar, Shashwat. 2019. "Job Preferences and Career Priorities." In *Youth in India: Aspirations, Attitudes, Anxieties*, eds. Sanjay Kumar. London: Routledge: 13–25.

Work in Progress

- Exit as 'Disengagement': The Political Implications of Economic Migration in Rural India [Under Review]
- The Price of Exit: Internal Migration, Public Goods, and Democratic Accountability in Rural India [Manuscript in Preparation]
- Environmental Shocks, Electoral Quotas, and Distributive Conflict (With Priyadarshi Amar, University Carlos III - Madrid, and Varun Karekurve-Ramachandra, University of Southern California) [Data Analysis]
- Disasters and Political Mobilization: Evidence from India (With Ritwika Basu, Indian Institute of Human Settlements) [Data Analysis]

Commentaries and Op-eds

- Verma, Rahul, and **Shashwat Dhar**. 2018. "The Muslims Voting for the BJP are Richer, More Educated and Conservative." *The Print* (21 September).
- Banerjee, Souradeep, and **Shashwat Dhar**. 2017. "Victory Sans Grandeur: The Gujarat Assembly Election 2017." *Economic and Political Weekly* 52(51): 12–14.
- **Dhar, Shashwat**. 2017. "Subnationalism: A Double-edged Sword." *The Hindu* (21 September).
- Gupta, Pranav, **Shashwat Dhar**, and Nitin Mehta. 2016. "In Bengal, BJP Fails to Build on 2014 Foundation." *The Indian Express* (22 May).
- **Dhar, Shashwat** and Krishanu B. Neog. 2016. "Google Can Inform, But Also Deceive." *The Hindu* (10 August).
- **Dhar, Shashwat**. 2015. "Academic Freedom in India is Nonexistent." *Fair Observer* (1 December).

Media Mentions

- "For migrants to Delhi, its welfare schemes, jobs, and lack of nativist politics are the biggest draw." *The Hindu* (2 May, 2023).
- "Where there's a bill there's a way to hide it!" *The Times of India* (15 November, 2022).

Grants/Awards

Faculty Research Grant, Swarthmore College ($4,000)	2025
Graduate School Travel Grant, Vanderbilt University ($1,000)	2024
Political Science Skill Building Fellowship, Vanderbilt University ($1,000)	2023
Research Award, University of Pennsylvania Center for the Advanced Study of India ($5,000)	2023
Primary Data Collection Research Grant, *SurveyCTO* ($4,376)	2022
Junior Research Fellowship, American Institute of Indian Studies ($15,000)	2022
Vina Sanyal Research Award, American Institute of Indian Studies ($1,000)	2022
Summer Research Award, Vanderbilt College of Arts and Science ($5,000)	2022
Field Research Grant, Latin American Public Opinion Project ($2,300)	2022
Summer Centennial Center Grant, American Political Science Association ($2,500)	2021
Dissertation Enhancement Grant, Russell G. Hamilton Graduate Leadership Institute, Vanderbilt University ($2,000)	2021
Graduate Arts & Science Fellowship, Vanderbilt College of Arts and Science	2018–24

Research Assistance

Center for Global Democracy, Vanderbilt University | Nashville, USA — Fall 2024

- Project: AmericasBarometer 2025
- Core responsibilities: Questionnaire design, cognitive pre-testing, data auditing and visualization, data cleaning and analysis

Tariq Thachil, Vanderbilt University | Nashville, USA — Fall 2018–Spring 2019

- Book Project: "Migrants and Machine Politics: How India's Urban Poor Seek Representation and Responsiveness"
- Key responsibilities: Merging quantitative datasets, coding qualitative data from interviews

Tata Institute of Social Sciences | Mumbai, India September 2017-July 2018

- Project: "Engaging Overseas Indian Electors"
- Key responsibilities: Crafting outreach messages to Indian diaspora, analyzing survey experimental data

Lokniti—Programme for Comparative Democracy | Delhi, India May 2016-2017

- Projects: Mood of the Nation Survey 2017, State Election Studies 2016-17, State of Democracy in South Asia II, Religious Attitudes, Behavior and Practices Survey 2015, National Election Study 2014
- Key responsibilities: Supervising survey operations, data quality control, statistical analysis of public opinion and election data, public writing

Aaditya Dar, George Washington University | Mumbai, India Nov–Dec 2015

- Project: "Politicians and Economic Development: Does Political Background Matter?"
- Key responsibilities: Building dataset on legislator bios, analyzing newspaper archives, and conducting interviews with journalists and elected officials

Tata Institute of Social Sciences | Mumbai, India Sep–Oct 2015

- Project: "Inclusive Elections in India: A Study on Domestic Migrants and Issues in Electoral Participation"
- Key responsibilities: Conducting literature reviews, technical writing, and liaising with the Election Commission of India

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record

Introduction to Global Studies Fall 2025, Fall 2026

Migration in a Globalized World Spring 2026

South Asia in Global Perspective: From Democracy to Conflict Spring 2026

Teaching Assistant

The Politics of Mexico
Instructor: Jonathan Hiskey Spring 2025

Identity Politics in the Non-Western World
Instructor: Nina McMurry Fall 2023

Guest Lecture: The Politics of Hindu-Muslim Conflict in South Asia

Justice: An Introduction, Section Instructor
Instructor: James Booth Spring 2022

Introduction to Comparative Politics
Instructor: Keith Weghorst Spring 2021

Democratization and Political Development
Instructor: Keith Weghorst Fall 2020

Guest Lecture: Social Determinants of Democratization

The Politics of Global Inequality
Instructor: Jonathan Hiskey Spring 2020

Middle East Politics
Instructor: Katherine Carroll Fall 2019

Conferences

Presentations

- Annual Conference on South Asia, University of Wisconsin-Madison 2026
- Midwest Political Science Association 2024, 2025, 2026
- American Political Science Association 2024

Discussant/Chair

- Midwest Political Science Association 2025, 2026
- Vanderbilt Comparative Politics Workshop 2018, 2019, 2021, 2022, 2023
- Midwest Workshop in Empirical Political Science III 2019

Invited Talks

- Guest Lecture, *An Overview of Diaspora Politics*, Vanderbilt University 2024
- SurveyCTO Webinar Series, Labor and Migration Research – Insights from India and Zambia 2024
- Pulse for Development Coffee Chat Series, *Support for Migrant Households: Lessons from the Pandemic*, Virtual 2022
- Graduate Student Workshop, *Navigating Fieldwork in Political Science* Fall 2023

Service

Reviewer, *Asian Ethnicity*	Fall 2026-Present
Faculty Steering Committee, Department of Peace & Conflict Studies	Fall 2026-Present
Co-coordinator, Global Conversation Lecture Series, Swarthmore	Fall 2025-Present
Global Studies Program Faculty Committee, Swarthmore	Fall 2025-Present
Vanderbilt Political Science Graduate Student Mentorship Program	2020–21
Resource Person, Lokniti-CSDS Summer Workshop on Quantitative Methods in Political Science	July 2016
Research Intern, World Wide Fund for Nature (WWF India)	July–Oct 2012
NREGA Social Audit, National Federation of Indian Women (NFIW)	June 2011

Skills

Languages: English (Professional), Hindi (Native), Kashmiri (Basic)
Programming: `R`, `Stata`, `NVivo`, `LaTeX`, `SurveyCTO`
Fieldwork in India: Bihar, Delhi, Haryana, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh

Other training

ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods, University of Michigan July 2023

- Causal Inference for the Social Sciences
- Regression Analysis II: Linear Models

References

Jonathan Hiskey
Professor of Political Science
Professor of Sociology (by courtesy)
Vanderbilt University
Email: j.hiskey@vanderbilt.edu

Nina McMurry
Assistant Professor of Political Science
Vanderbilt University
Email: nina.mcmurry@vanderbilt.edu

Tariq Thachil
Professor of Political Science
University of Pennsylvania
Email: thachil@sas.upenn.edu